We kept competing when Australia batted for a second time. In fact, we appeared to be right back in the game when they stumbled to 162 for seven but, as ever, just as we threatened, just as they wobbled, they seemed to find another gear. Brad Haddin and their lower order scored runs. The tail wagged. We simply could not close and, when they were finally all out for 319, our target had grown and grown and grown, reaching 414.

That seemed to be just about that, ran the consensus.

'Stuff that,' Graeme Smith figuratively told the consensus. Our captain settled and began to score freely. Hashim also settled and began to score freely. The runs flowed and our total passed 100, and then 150 and, watching on TV in our changing room, some of us began to wonder. No, it was surely too many.

We reached 172 for one and were just starting to dare to dream ... when, like two meaty slaps to the face, Graeme and Hash fell within three overs. Jacques and I came together at 179 for three, and played a few strokes, still swimming against the tide and reaching stumps on the fourth day at 227 for three.

*Please forgive me*
*If I act a little strange*
*For I know not what I do*

Jacques and I are walking to the crease on the fifth morning. Just over 5 000 people have turned up to watch the last rites at the WACA and, as far as I can tell, the Australian players appear unconcerned. Following the retirement of the Waugh brothers, of McGrath and Warne, they are not the team they once were, but they are still strong and they know it. They believe and they strut. I envy their self-assurance.

While batting in our first innings, I had decided to try to transfer some pressure to their spinner, Jason Krejza. I charged down the wicket. He